Nintendo theme park
Nintendo and Universal are working on a Super Nintendo World theme park to open by 2020.
http://dgit.in/SprNntndoWrld

Panasonic's shopping system
Panasonic releases a demo of their new shopping system that can automatically bag and generate your bills
http://dgit.in/PansoncBl

Smartwatches are pretty cool to look at, and they can do a lot of interesting stuff if you set them up right. The question, though, is, in these times of rapid technological change, when we might just leapfrog from VR goggles to smart contacts in ten years, do smartwatches have a future? Are smartwatches our interface with tomorrow?

What smartwatches can (and can't) do

If we want to answer that question, we need to first look at what smartwatches can actually do, in the here and now. As we'll argue later, it's not so much that there's a shortage of use cases for smartwatches. Rather, low adoption rates, amateur software, and a fragmented ecosystem mean that the solutions are rarely more effective than what you could just get done with your phone. Sports and fitness are among some of the use cases where smartwatches really shine, and can give your phone a run for its money in terms of features and convenience. While we can't speak for the Apple Watch, the 360 does a great job of fitness tracking. When you head out for a jog, Android Wear devices do a good job of keeping track of your timing, distance, and heart-rate (with the rather dubious heart-rate monitor on the Moto 360). And while much of this is possible with a pedometer app on your phone, the increased convenience of smartwatches really makes a difference here. Also, it's one of the few cases where you don't need an active phone connection to your watch. Unfortunately, personal fitness isn't much of a priority for many, and a cheap fitness band, like the Mi Band, can get your virtually all of this functionality at a fraction of the price.

While the latest generation of smartwatches feature standalone mobile internet connectivity, most of the devices out in the wild, including the first and second-gen Moto 360, are entirely reliant on a Bluetooth-paired phone to connect. While standalone connectivity is a step in the right direction, most smartwatches are inextricably tied to their paired phones. This reduces their utility right from the get go because it introduces an element of redundancy: whatever's on your watch has been passed through from your phone where it's almost certainly available in more detail. Because of Android Wear's inherent limitations, you really can't get a full-fledged app experience on your watch: Although WhatsApp,

Moto 360 2nd Gen

for instance, displays your current messages, you don't get to see the whole history, and can't even type out replies without using a third-party input method. Although Android Wear 2.0 is slated to ease things in this respect—with handwriting support, and the ability for apps to run independently of your phone—between the small screen and the limited battery life making it necessary to leave said screen switched off as much as possible, you're just not going to have a comparable experience to what you can do with a phone that's only a pocket-whip away.

The use-case dilemma

There are quite a few cases where the Android Wear solution is compelling, but it's either a hassle to set up, or where redundancy makes pulling out your phone as easy an alternative. Take media centre remotes, for instance. In theory, a media remote that works off Android Wear is the perfect complement for a laid-back living room Netflix binge. In practice, the complex jerry-rigging that's going on here, with your watch talking to your phone, that's talking to your HTPC, means that connection drop-outs are the rule, rather than the exception. It's cool to use, and the convenience is tantalizing, but at the end of the day, you're apt to just pull out your phone, and use that to control your media centre. E-book reading is another area where, surprisingly, Wear does have its uses. The unassumingly named Wear Reader makes best possible use of limited screen space: it flashes words at you, one by one, onscreen. This works a lot better than you think it would, and if you don't mind flipping erm...rewinding whenever you lose focus, it's a surprisingly easy way to read, though it does run through your battery. But the question that arises here is, again, why can't you just pull out your phone? Because of the greater amount of screen space, there's no need for gimmicky flashing of any kind. Market evidence points to precisely what we'd expect for a device that people just can't find a suitable niche for in their lives: A Gartner survey indicates that smartwatches have a 29 per cent abandonment rate. In other words, one in three smartwatches is currently gathering dust in a drawer because their owners haven't been able to find compelling uses for them.

Although the lack of a mature app environment is a concern, the real issue here is a bit more fundamental: As things stand now, there aren't a lot use cases where software is tailored towards a wearable experience. There is so much more that a connected device on your wrist ought to be able to do than merely act as a second screen for your smartphone. While native messaging options are rudimentary—voice commands and a small selection of auto replies are about it—third party options like Coffee and Wear Messenger are surprisingly complete messaging solutions. There are all kinds of situations where it's not feasible or appropriate to pull out your smartphone. Shooting off quick messages from Wear—the "Wher r u" variety—without pulling yourself out of whatever you're doing, is a solution that only a wearable device can offer. With Android Wear 2.0 featuring